Date: March 25, 2025

To: Dr. Paul Coakley, Superintendent, MESD
Multnomah County Superintendents and Inter-district Transfer Staff

CC: Judy Brennan, PPS Enrollment Director

From: Superintendent Kimberlee Armstrong

Subject: Right to Return Student Transfer Update

Introduction

We are pleased to share with you a summary of results for the Right to Return transfer option. Over the past two years the agreement between Portland, David Douglas, Parkrose and Reynolds school districts has allowed 27 students to enroll into inner North/Northeast Portland schools through a streamlined process.

We expect interest in the program to grow as more families learn about the opportunity. Growth could also occur if additional partner districts sign onto the agreement.

Background

Urban renewal and gentrification have resulted in the displacement of students and families to neighboring communities and cities, disproportionately impacting Black Portland residents whose children attended schools in North and Northeast Portland.

In July 2017, Portland Black and civil rights leaders provided public testimony to the PPS Board of Education requesting a “right to return" opportunity for children of families displaced from the Albina community in Northeast Portland. The request was initially addressed through an Open Enrollment “Return to Albina” transfer option. However, that state transfer mechanism sunset in 2018, and subsequent discussions with ODE leaders about adding displacement as a factor in state intradistrict transfer policies were paused during the pandemic.

ODE engaged a consultant to review a permanent rule change in 2021. The consultant ultimately determined that because so much time had passed since the idea was originally presented, there may not be significant interest in the transfer option, and recommended that PPS proceed with a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with its neighboring districts. Multnomah County district superintendents reviewed and responded to a draft Right to Return plan in Fall 2022. David Douglas, Parkrose and Reynolds school districts agreed to the MOU in Winter 2023, while Centennial and Gresham-Barlow school districts chose not to enter into the agreement.

What is “Right to Return”?

Right to Return is an enrollment opportunity for students whose families have been harmed by urban renewal practices in North/Northeast Portland. Families who were displaced from

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North/Northeast Portland neighborhoods but wish to have their children attend schools in this area can be approved for transfer through a single application, even if they reside in a different school district. Approved students do not have to reapply to remain in PPS, and transfers cannot be revoked due to attendance or behavior concerns. The agreement does not include transportation.

The program is generally based upon the City of Portland's North/Northeast Housing Priority, and preference zone which provides housing opportunities for families who have been harmed by urban renewal practices in North/Northeast Portland.

Right to Return Transfer Results: 2023-24 through 2024-25

PPS launched the Right to Return application and website in April 2023. The information was shared with partner districts, schools located in the Right to Return zone and community partners.

PPS received 24 Right to Return applications for the 2023-24 school year. 23 were approved and one student was denied due to space limitations at the requested school. For the 2024-25 school year, PPS received six applications; four were approved and two were denied due to lack of space.

Chart 1 shows the current enrollment status of students approved to PPS schools through Right to Return transfers.

Chart 1: Status of Right to Return (RTR) Transfers 2023-24 through 2024-25

Approved RFR School	Continuing RTR	Continuing-moved back to PPS	Attending different PPS school	Unenrolled	Graduated	Total
Boise-Eliot/Humboldt ES	2					**2**
Dr ML King Jr ES	2	2		2		**6**
Irvington ES	1					**1**
Faubion K-8	2					**2**
Vernon K-8	2					**2**
Harriet Tubman MS		1		1		**2**
Grant HS			1			**1**
Jefferson HS	4		1		1	**6**
McDaniel HS	2			1		**3**
Roosevelt HS	1		1			**2**
Total	**16**	**3**	**3**	**4**	**1**	**27**

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The chart below shows the distribution of Right to Return approvals by home district and student race/ethnicity.

Chart 2: Right to Return Students 2023-24 through 2024-25 by Home District and Race

	Student Race			
Home District	**Black**	**Hispanic**	**Multiracial**	**White**
David Douglas	5	3	1	
Parkrose	8	1	1	1
Reynolds	3	1	3	
Total	**16**	**5**	**5**	**1**

Next Steps

Right to Return applications for the 2025-26 school year will be available beginning April 15, 2025. We appreciate the commitment of our partner district to publicize the application through their websites.

We recommend adding the phrase "*so long as the student remains actively enrolled in a PPS school.*" to the Right to Return application to clarify that students are not guaranteed a continuing seat if they unenroll from the district. In such a circumstance, a family would have to submit a new application and approval would be based on space availability. A revised application highlighting the change is attached.

As always, additional partner districts are encouraged to join the program, and feedback is welcome.

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Attachments

Right to Return website
Right to Return application (updated)